

TANGO AND CASH

■ By Kimi Dangor

Jhatkas and matkas aside, Bollywood's dance factory is fast discovering ballroom dancing. From 'one, two, pelvic thrust' to 'one, two, cha cha cha', here's a groove routine that's all set to stay. From dance studios to film studios, classical ballroom sashays and seductive Latin ballroom moves are bringing a new flavour to filmi hits.

When childhood-friends-turned-lovers Aspi and Zara broke into a spontaneous tango in Reema Kagti's *Honeymoon Travels Pvt Ltd*, it was the result of hours of dizzying labour for actors Abhay Deol and Minissha Lamba. Choreographers Danny, 28, Kunjan, 29 and Savio, 25, put them through rigorous motions to get the tango timing just right. The result was a dance sequence that caught the nation's fancy and considerably surged the admission charges at ballroom dance institutes across the country.

Swivelling to salsa, cavorting to the cha-cha or dancing the rumba, Bollywood's boogie brigade is fast catching up with the magic of the ballroom genre that has been explored by Hollywood in the Grand Fred Astaire-Ginger Rogers dance-a-thons and movies like *Dance With Me* and *Shall We Dance*.

And even as the high heels and flirty skirts come out to play, experts like ballroom guru Sandip Soparrkar, 30, are reaping the benefits of this new craze. "Dance trends are cyclical, just like fashion fads," says Soparrkar. From Kishore Kumar's jiving antics and Helen's cha-cha numbers to Mithun's disco moves and Prabhu Deva's break-dancing debut, Bollywood now seems to have come a full circle. "Audiences today are travelling all over the world and are exposed to other cultures. And since our films are going global, why not our dance moves?" he asks.

Having choreographed elaborate ballroom sequences in films like

From cha-cha to disco to break-dance, the movie industry has broken boundaries on the dance floor. Now the boogie brigade is learning the subtle art of waltzing feet and shimmying hips.



DANCE WITH ME: Choreographers Danny and Kunjan salsa in the reality show *Nach Baliye*

Zubeidaa, *Kyun Ho Gaya Na* and the Dino Morea-starrer *Holiday*, Soparrkar is currently working on N. Chandra's Latin dance-based film *Cyclone*, rumoured to be inspired by *Dance With Me*. "Salsa, jive, cha-cha, samba, tango and waltz are some of the ballroom dance forms that are becoming popular in Bollywood circles," accedes Soparrkar.

After Deol and Lamba's tango-tangle got noticed, choreographing team Danny, Kunjan and Savio are ready to move on from their *Nach Baliye* success and take on some more film projects. Says Danny, "The Latin dance market is definitely picking up. We have seen a 20 per cent increase in the demand for our live performances featuring salsa and jive. That translates on-screen as well.

People want to see something new. How many of the same old Bollywood dances can you watch in movie after movie?" This demand for innovation is keeping the trio busy. "We will soon be choreographing a song for Kunal Khemu's forthcoming film (untitled as yet), where jive and salsa will be used," says partner Kunjan.

For filmmaker Ananth Narayan Mahadevan's forthcoming movie *Anamika*, the choice of a salsa and jive medley was a forgone decision as he wanted to do something different. The song, evocative of an 18th century masquerade ball in France, sees Dino Morea and Minissha Lamba in a regal salsa and jive sequence. "Audiences are exhausted with the surfeit of the same old dance and music they are subjected to. And since we were shooting a royal masquerade ball, we decided to do something different," says Mahadevan. Choreographer Piyush Panchal, 31, rehearsed for five days with Morea and Lamba for the special sequence. Panchal, who has made actors dance to his tunes in films like *Style*, *Saathiya* and *Taxi No. 9211* believes variety adds spice to a song's picturisation. "Today, Indians are watching Hollywood films and enjoying ballroom dance sequences. And though we can't replicate a classic waltz or other intricate moves in a typical Bollywood scenario, we can use the movements and give them a *desi* twist," says Panchal.

Giving this trend another spin are Akshaye Khanna

